

What the Ledger Says

Saelunere, Episode Four

Parvo, in the year 756

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Lark and Calder and Felix came up out of the Bellows into the Stacks a little after midnight, with Harriet Spurnhold between them and the ledger under Lark's arm. Behind them the second day of winter turned over into the third, and not one of the four noticed it happen.

They ran a long way first. Up out of the tunnels and on through the dark streets, turning corners for the sake of turning them, until none of them could keep it up any longer. Then they stopped and stood still and listened.

There was nothing behind them. No boots, no voices, nothing at all coming up out of the hole they had climbed out of.

After that they walked, because not one of them had anything left to run with.

Lark had carried the ledger the whole way. She had taken it off the broken howl that died with it in its jaws, and the first thing she did when they stopped was push it into Felix's hands.

Then she went to the wall and was sick.

It was not the running. In the space of one evening, a woman in a green coat had got a hand round her throat and lifted her off the ground. A silent man had pulled a rope tight round her neck in a public square. A construct built for the purpose had knocked her flat and stood on her chest until she stopped moving.

Somewhere in the middle of the last of those, something had come up out of her that had never come up before, and had burned its way out through her skin, and had taken whatever it needed to do that.

Her body had held all of it together for exactly as long as there was a reason to.

Calder stood in the middle of the street and waited for her.

He was holding himself very carefully. Shoulders square, hands still, the whole arrangement of a man in control of his own evening. Lark straightened up and wiped her mouth and looked at his eyes, and his eyes were racing, and nothing else about him matched them at all.

She walked over and got hold of his wrist.

“Calder. What were you thinking?”

“What do you mean?”

“Why did you just run there when she got shot?” She had not let go of the wrist. “You ran in and you chased after a man with a gun. What were you going to even do to him if you got to him?”

Calder did not answer straight away.

“I don’t know,” he said. “It was just a reaction. Theo got shot. That man has to be connected, they’re interested in Theo’s house, or the book.” He stopped and went at it from somewhere more honest. “I’m tired of these mysteries. I want to know what is actually going on. And I felt like he was one piece of the puzzle.”

“It’s not going to be helpful if you just die.” Lark said it flatly. “You shouldn’t chase after a man with a gun like that. You’re going to get shot yourself and then you’re not going to help anyone.”

“That is true.” He said it to the cobbles. “That is true. I lost the proper thinking over there. I overreacted. I’ll try to be calm next time.”

“And the howls.” She had let go of him by now. “I’ve never seen them behave like that. They’ve been made to do that, and I wouldn’t get that close to one again.”

“They were very dangerous.” And then, because she had asked and because he had not said it to anybody yet: “When I came round into that tunnel, the thing was standing there. A metre from me. It scared me very much. I did not like being there at all. Luckily Felix was nearby, so I could run back to him.”

Lark nodded, and did not make him say any more about it.

“Thank you for the help. Both of you.” She said it to Calder and back over her shoulder to Felix. “I don’t think we’d have got out of there alive without either of you.”

“I have never been in danger like that before.” Calder was looking back the way they had come. “These people are something else entirely. Not like the ordinary criminals I have run into.”

“We’re much more involved now. That’s for certain.” Lark was going through it in her head as she spoke. “And a lot of our faces are attached to a lot of other people now.” She looked at Felix, and past him at the woman standing quietly on the edge of the group. “Those two are probably on a list somewhere.”

“Probably all of us,” Calder said. “The man on the wall saw our faces too. He was shooting at us. He wanted us dead.”

* * *

Harriet Spurnhold had not said anything for most of that.

There was a burn across the side of her throat where the shot had gone through, closed over by whatever Felix had put into it on the floor of that chamber. She had no house, no post and no guild, and she had been walking for twenty minutes through a part of the city she did not know. Felix asked whether she had anywhere safe to go.

“No. Well. I’ve been staying with a friend, or I planned to.” She shook her head. “I don’t think it’s safe to go back there now. I don’t want to put her in any danger.” A pause. “Do you have anywhere we can go?”

Nobody did. Felix had a satchel and no home, Lark had a sheet with everything she owned knotted into it, and Calder had a bed in a College he could not bring any of this into.

Harriet worked something out in the silence.

“I think, if it’s all right with you all, I would rather not be any further involved in this.” She had clearly put the words in order before she used them. “I am going to find a way to disappear. I have friends on the other side of the city. I will lie low.” She looked round at the three of them. “No offence is meant by it. But I don’t think I should spend any more time with anybody here, if it means danger for everybody. They are after me as much as they are after Felix. That was an ambush meant for me. I don’t believe they knew any of you would be there at all.” She pulled her coat straight. “So I will bring danger wherever I go. It’s best that I go on my own.”

“Thank you for the ledger,” Felix said.

“I can’t tell you much more about it than I did. It’s a record of the work.” She almost smiled. “I’m sure you’ll be able to decipher it. If you do need to reach me, a sending, if you have access to anything like that.”

“We’ll figure it out,” Felix said.

“Then I wish you the best.” She stopped, and for the first time that night she

sounded less like a chief secretary and more like a woman standing in a street at one in the morning. "I had not planned to get involved in any of this."

"Good luck with everything," Calder said.

"And to you as well."

She took a left turn off the road, and went into the dark between two buildings, and was gone.

* * *

That left the three of them standing in a street with nowhere to be.

Felix said he would find a tavern. Any tavern with a door still open, because crossing the city at this hour was a worse idea than paying for a bed. Calder said he would go back to the College, which is about as safe a building as there is in Parvo.

Then he said, to nobody in particular, that he was not sure he wanted to be on his own tonight.

Nobody had an answer to that, and he did not ask again. Lark said she needed the night to herself and turned towards the Stacks, and the three of them agreed to find each other tomorrow without agreeing on where, which is the sort of arrangement people make at one in the morning.

* * *

While all of that was happening, on the other side of the city, Billiam had come in off the back step to tell Aeska to leave.

There was nobody in the room to tell.

His mother was still making up beds. She had carried mats through into Billiam's room and laid them out along the floor, four of them, for the guests who had gone out earlier in the evening and not come back, and she went on laying them out while she explained.

"Oh, Billy, yes. Your friend Aeska had to." She thought about it. "Well, actually, I'm not sure what he needed to do. He said he had to leave. So I suppose he won't be staying."

"He just left?"

"He made his excuses and left. He asked me to give you his thanks. For every-

thing.” She shook a blanket out. “So I suppose he changed his mind about staying.”
Billiam’s father came in behind him from the yard.

“Good.” Benjamin did not break stride. “The less you see of him, the better, I suppose.”

He was already gathering up the papers he had come for.

“It’s late. I don’t know who these people are that you’re running about with, or whether they’re coming back here.” He did not stop moving while he said it. “Think carefully about your choices over the next few days. And stay away from the guild. If things come to the worst, well. You know my thoughts.”

“Yeah.” Billiam had not moved from the middle of the room. “You’ve been very clear, Dad.”

“I must go. I need to be there first thing.”

He got to the door with the research under his arm. On the way past his wife he put one arm halfway round her and nodded at her over the top of it, which is not what a man does to his wife after four days away, and then he was gone down the balcony.

Annie let a breath out, and turned round with the last blanket still in her hands.

“So. Well.” She was being bright about it. “Billy, what about your other friends? That Felix fellow, and what was her name, Lark. Are they staying?”

“I don’t know, Mum.”

He went to his room. He had no way of reaching any of them, no sending and no letter and no notion which quarter of the city each of them was in, and he lay down on his own bed with four empty mats on the floor beside it.

Nobody came.

* * *

Aeska came at the Plumb and Bob the long way round and did not go in until he had walked past it twice.

The shutters were down and there was nothing to see through them. He went to the back door with the key Harl had given him, and got it open quietly enough, and crossed the back room he had slept over for two nights. Then he pushed the inner door, and it went across the boards with a noise that filled the whole quiet room.

There was one man in it. Harl was still working along the bar with a cloth, at the end of the day.

“Oh. Aeska.” He straightened up. “Glad you’re all right. Bit of a tussle in the square, I heard.”

“Yes. Sorry about that.” Aeska came the rest of the way in. “We had to leave quickly. I couldn’t tell you anything.” A beat. “How has it been? Have you had any trouble? With those two, or anybody else, after the commotion?”

“Those two from the square.” Harl put the cloth down. “They came back. And they took that fella. Barry.”

Aeska stopped where he was.

“Took him away with them,” Harl said. “On account of him being the only one they could get hold of, I suppose. Haven’t seen him since.” He shrugged, and it was not a careless shrug. “There’s talk about the business in the square. Seemed like a dangerous sort of people you were dealing with.”

“Do you know anything about them?”

“Not really. Porter’s Guild, from the colours, the greens. Outside of that, no idea. They never introduced themselves to me.” He thought about it. “I don’t reckon Barry knew them either. When they came back in he didn’t recognise them. They just decided he was worth something.”

“They were looking for anybody with a connection to Theo.” Aeska was working it as he said it. “So they went and found out that he had been at the meetings.”

“What do you think it’s all about?” Harl leaned on his own bar. “I never had Theo down as the sort to get wrapped up in. Well. They didn’t look like nice sorts of people.”

“I have no idea either.” Aeska said it to the bar rather than to Harl. “I got separated from the others. I hope they found something. I’ll have to find them tomorrow.”

Aeska asked whether he could stay the night. Harl said yes, and then did not stop there.

“You paid up well in advance, so I’m happy enough. But I’ve got to say.” He gave it a second. “Twice in two nights. That’s a lot of trouble for one house.” He was not enjoying himself. “And as much as I like and respect you, it’s going to start costing me custom.” “So take it as a warning, right? The sooner you can get yourself out of whatever this is, the better for both of us.”

“Of course. That’s exactly why I am here on my own tonight and not with the rest of them.” Aeska put his hands up. “Sorry for all the trouble. We didn’t think it would find us this close.”

* * *

Salador's slip is a three-storey house in the Stacks with a bath cut into the floor of the bottom room.

Whoever built it dug down through the boards until they struck the essence pipework that runs under the street. Those pipes are hot and stay hot. They laid the bath straight over the top of them. Nobody has ever called that legal. Nobody has ever complained about it either, because it is the only hot water for six streets, and in a district where most people wash out of a bucket a thing like that is worth more than a licence.

Lark arrived at half past midnight, covered in blood.

The doorman, Emory, knew her. He is young, and does not look like a man who could stop anybody, and at that hour he was half asleep on his stool with the door propped open for the last guests to leave rather than for any to arrive.

"Oh." He got one eye open. "Lark."

"Sorry. Is Nell working? Or Delia? Could I get in to talk to them?"

"It's really past our opening, Lark," Emory said.

"I know. I'm sorry. It's important."

He looked at her properly then and came all the way awake.

"Look. We're trying to run a high class establishment here." He was up off the stool. "And we can't have bloody people walking off the street in the middle of the night."

So Lark tried to go past him.

It was not a sensible plan and it did not work. He got an arm round her waist as she went, and he turned out to be a great deal stronger than a man his size and age has any business being, and he put her back down on the step.

"I said we're trying to run a high class establishment. What are you doing?"

"I need to get in. I need to talk to the girls, it's important." She had stopped struggling. "Otherwise I'm sleeping on the street tonight."

"You should have thought about that before you turned up at half past midnight."

"Please."

He looked at her for a moment longer.

"Let me get Delia. Wait there." He pointed at the step. "You're not coming in."

Delia is the oldest of the women who work there and runs the rest of them like a big sister. She was still up and still working when he fetched her, and she took one look at the doorway and pushed him bodily out of it.

"Emory. Emory, get out of the way. What are you doing?" And then, to Lark, in a completely different voice: "Look at you. You look a mess."

"I am. I'm sorry." Lark had her hands together. "Would I be able to get in, just for the night? I'll make it up to you. I promise."

“You don’t have to make it up to me, love.” Delia stood back to let her past. “You’ve got to make it up to Madame Rooke. And she is not going to be happy in the morning when she hears about this.”

“Then let me clean.”

Delia stopped.

“I’ll clean the place. Tonight. All of it.” Lark was already looking past her at the floor. “Then it isn’t for nothing.”

“Sure. Yes. All right, come in, come in, come in.” She got her through the door and shut it. “Look, it’s not on me. I’m going to say you turned up and refused to leave until you’d helped clean, and then you can sort out everything else yourself in the morning.” She was already heading for the stairs. “Nell’s room, second on the left. You know it.” A last look back. “And don’t mess anything up, because that will be on my head.”

So Lark cleaned the bathhouse.

She washed herself first, in the corner, getting the second lot of another person’s blood off her in two days. Then she scrubbed the bath out, and swept the floors, and went over the surfaces and the stairs and everything else she could reach. It took her until somewhere around two in the morning.

It is work she has done before and is good at, and it cost her the whole of what was left of the night, and she did not think about that for a moment. The alternative was a doorway in the Stacks in Tide.

Then she went up the wooden stairs as quietly as she could manage, past five doors, and knocked on the sixth.

There was shuffling on the other side of it, and a long wait, and then the door came open on Nell with her hair flat on one side and her eyes barely working.

“Oh my God.” Her hand went over her own mouth. “Lark. What are you doing here?”

“Shh. Sorry.”

“Come in, come in, come in.”

It is a small room with one bed in it and not much floor. Nell pulled her inside and shut the door and stood there in the dark, still mostly asleep.

“It’s two in the morning.”

“I know. I’m going to sleep here tonight.” Lark had already put her bundle down. “Don’t worry, I can roll up really small on the floor. It’s fine. I have my things. And tomorrow I’m going to convince Madame Rooke that I’m useful and that I can keep doing this. Maybe I’ll even get a room.”

Nell looked at the foot of floor, and at her.

“You’re not sleeping on the floor. We’ll share.”

They got into the bed.

“She was in a good mood this morning,” Nell said into the pillow. “Madame Rooke. So she might be all right with you tomorrow. But you know how she gets.” A pause that went on long enough that Lark thought she had gone. “You’ll have to be there early. She’s up at seven, doing the books.”

“I don’t get up that early,” Nell said, into the pillow. “I work late. That one’s on you.”

Lark set her timer on the floor by her head, close enough that she would hear it, and told it seven.

* * *

Billiam’s mother had an early shift, so the house was empty when he woke. He ate on his own and walked to work lost in his own thoughts.

What he was turning over, all the way down the ladders and across towards the Core, was his father and Aeska.

Those two had known each other on sight. His father had the name and the house it belonged to before anybody in that room said either out loud. And then he had taken his son out to the yard and spent an hour telling him to give the man up.

There was something in that. Billiam could not get hold of it, but he could feel the edges.

He was still working at it when he pushed the gate of Claringbold’s Yard open, and so it took him a moment to notice that the gate had not been latched.

The yard was quiet, and it was the wrong sort of quiet. He is usually the last of the shift in, and there should have been two or three men already at work among the stacks of scrap, and there was nobody.

Then he heard something coming across the yard towards him, and the sound of it was wrong.

There are two constructs at Claringbold’s. A pair of bullyboys, which are the big four-legged ones built for hauling, and Billiam has looked after both of them for two years. A bullyboy has no head at all, only a broad flat set of shoulders with a great round lamp between them that does for eyes and ears and everything else it needs. They walk in an even four beats, and you hear one long before you see it.

What Billiam heard was three beats where there should have been four, and the whole weight of the thing coming down wrong on every turn of it.

Shepherd came round the stacks towards him on three legs. One of the back

ones was gone at the joint. The body tipped down onto the empty corner at every stride and caught itself and heaved up again, ka-clunk, ka-clunk, all the way across the yard. Then it put its lamp against his chest, exactly as it does every morning.

“Shepherd.” Billiam had both hands on it. “What’s happened to you?”

The construct pushed its shoulder against him, and kept pushing, moving him off the path towards the side of the yard. He let himself be moved.

The other one was round the corner.

Steam Bun was on his side with steam coming up out of him, and one leg still turning over slowly in the air, trying to walk. Billiam got down next to him. Something heavy had come down on the top of the shoulder and driven the whole housing in against the side.

Steam Bun is old. He is years past what a construct of that make is meant to last, and the only reason he moves at all is that Billiam has spent two years putting him back together a piece at a time.

“All right.” He put a hand flat on the casing. “Hang in there, buddy. I’ll be right back.”

He went to the office. The door was open and swinging on its hinges.

Inside, everything had been pulled out. The desk was smashed open. The drawers were on the floor and everything that had been in them was all over the room. Billiam stood in the middle of it and made himself look at it properly, rather than only at the mess. He could not tell whether there had been a fight. There was no blood anywhere, and nothing was broken in the way things break when men are throwing each other about, but everything that could be opened had been opened by somebody with the strength to do it fast and no interest at all in what the room looked like afterwards.

Shrapnel, who runs the yard and has run it a long time, was not there.

At the back of the office was the secure drawer where the day’s takings went. It had been broken open and there was nothing in it, which told Billiam very little, because Shrapnel had said to him more than once that he never left money on the premises overnight and took it away with him every evening.

Nobody was in the back room either. He had never been into the back room in his life and stood in it not knowing what was supposed to be there, which meant he had no way of telling what had gone.

He went back out to the constructs and spent the rest of the morning on them.

He is not an engineer. He is a lad who strips machines for parts and has picked up enough along the way to keep two old bullyboys running. What he had in his pockets were his own tools for map work, and nothing in them was any use here. There was nothing at all he could do about a leg that was not there. He

got the crushed plate off Steam Bun's shoulder and then could not get anything underneath it to move. He worked at it for hours with the yard silent around him, and at the end of it Shepherd was still on three legs and Steam Bun still could not get up.

Nobody came to work. Not one of them, all morning.

* * *

Across the city the timer went off by Lark's head at seven, after four hours of the worst sleep she had ever had, and she was up and down the stairs before anybody else in the building had stirred.

She pushed her bundle under Nell's bed. Then she went through the whole of the ground floor again: lit the water so the bath would be warm when it was wanted, went over the floors, ran a finger along the tops of things and found nothing on it anywhere. The place was as clean as she could make it, and she had made it that way herself, and she went up two flights of stairs knowing it.

The door at the top is heavier than the others and better made. Lark knocked on it.

"Come in."

Madame Rooke was at her books. She is an older woman with salt and pepper hair and a good overcoat with the collar up, not showy but plainly expensive, and rings on several fingers. She was wearing half moon spectacles and she pulled them down her nose to look at Lark over the top of them, and if anything about a stranger in her doorway at seven in the morning surprised her, none of it reached her face.

"I do not believe you are one of my employees."

"Well." Lark came a careful step in. "Not yet."

"Firstly," said Madame Rooke, "you look like shit."

"Yes. It was a rough night. I'm sorry about that."

"I expect employees here to have a sense of decorum. Let us say that we keep our standards a little higher than many of the places in the Stacks you may be used to." She put the pen down. "Anybody working for me pays attention to how she appears to a guest."

"I understand. And I'm offering to do anything at all that doesn't need me to be seen by the customers." Lark had both hands knotted together at her waist and was trying to sound useful. "I can do the dirtiest and the darkest jobs in this place. Well. Not the darkest, because I don't know what that would specifically mean."

Madame Rooke looked at her over the spectacles for a moment.

"My dear," she said. "The dirtiest and darkest jobs in this establishment are with the customers."

"I did not mean that." Lark had gone a colour. "I meant scrubbing. Keeping the baths clean, keeping the rooms clean. The jobs nobody is excited to do."

"Again, I am not certain what you imagine people are excited to do here. But I take your point, however you are attempting to phrase it."

She let Lark stand there a moment, and then got down to it.

"I understand what you are offering, and there is certainly a great deal of work to be done. I can say with some pride that we are quite successful and can always use another pair of hands." The spectacles came off altogether. "But before I make any promises I need to know rather more about you. I cannot take a person off the street, no offence intended, and put her to work in my establishment. You might be a thief. You might be a murderer." She considered. "I will say you do not look like a murderer. But who knows. Where are you from? What did you do before this? And why are you arriving at bathhouses in the middle of the night, covered in blood, I might add."

Somebody had already told her exactly how Lark had arrived.

"My name is Lark. I'm from the Bellows, and the Stacks." She kept it straight. "I worked as a courier this last year. I had to quit, for a reason." And then, deliberately, because gossip is a currency and she wanted to be seen spending some: "Let's just say I don't like the Porter's Guild very much. And I don't want to be associated with them."

"You worked for the Porter's Guild," Madame Rooke said. "Which outfit?"

"The Brassline crew. Just up the road."

"Mira." There was no surprise in it at all. "Runs the crew. I know her, of course."

Lark tried to read the face that went with it and could not find anything in it to read.

"And before the Porters?" said Madame Rooke.

"A lot of different things. You work for a lot of people, down in the Bellows." She picked her way along it. "Mostly gathering and acquiring things from various places, and delivering them."

"That sounds like a thief, my dear," Madame Rooke said.

"I wouldn't know anything about that." A pause. "I've never been accused of anything like it."

"Never been accused." Madame Rooke's mouth moved very slightly. "I see that you pick your words carefully, and I respect it."

She turned a page she was not reading.

"A great many people come out of the Bellows with, let us say, intentions to

improve their station, and I mean that in the kindest way available to me. There is a great deal to be gained by working one's way up. It does occasionally produce some unsavoury characters, and I would not paint the whole of the Bellows with that brush, but those who begin with the least are often the ones most willing to take advantage of a situation." She looked up. "Which is why I am careful."

"I understand. I've known plenty of people like that as well."

"I am sure you have."

Then she closed the ledger in front of her, which she had not been reading for some minutes.

"How much do you know about what we do here? I do not mean the day to day, the mundane business of a bathhouse. I mean that I have a number of, let us say, friends, who from time to time need information about certain things, or certain people. And I procure that information for them, in exchange for a fee. A service." She let that hang in the air for a moment. "Do not take this the wrong way. But you do not look like a cleaning girl. The sort of person one employs for that does not arrive covered in blood in the middle of the night."

"I very much hope that isn't going to be a regular occurrence," Lark said.

"It is a rare one indeed. But I think you may have some additional skills that would be of rather more use to me." A small movement of one ringed hand. "Do you know the Stacks well?"

"Yes, ma'am. Some parts of it especially."

"And do you know the Plumb and Bob?" Madame Rooke said.

Lark did not let anything at all show.

"Yes."

"Excellent." Madame Rooke sat back. "There are rumours that a certain fallen nobleman's son has been seen at the Plumb and Bob, and I will say that this information is particularly valuable to some of my clients. I would like you to verify it for me. If you can bring me some proof that this Aeska Volan, I believe the name is, is presently at that tavern, or performs there, or is at least known to the people who drink in it." She spread her fingers. "Find that out for me, and you will have a place here, and I shall reward you gladly besides."

"I'll do my best," Lark said.

"It would be in your best interest to do your best."

She had not raised her voice, or sharpened it. It was the same voice she had offered her the job in.

"You have a debt to me at this point. I appreciate the cleaning, truly, but it does not pay for the intrusion you have made on this establishment in the middle of the night. And if you would prefer that your friend Nell did not suffer any consequences for the harbouring of a potential fugitive." She let the sentence finish

itself. "Then you will be particularly diligent. I am sure."

"Again. I'm sorry for the disturbance." Lark's voice had gone quiet and stayed level. "I did my best not to be seen, and I did my best to clean the place. And I'll do my best with what you've asked."

She picked up the pen and went back to her books, and spoke to them rather than to Lark.

"I shall expect you back tomorrow at the latest."

* * *

Lark went down to the floor below, into Nell's room, where Nell was still asleep, and knelt by the bed and got hold of her shoulder.

"I met her."

"Mm."

"I met Madame Rooke, and she's asking me for a lot more than I thought." Lark shook her, gently. "Do you think she's nice? Do you trust her? Is she a good person? You have to tell me before I do anything."

Nell got one eye open.

"What do you mean, nice? She runs this place. She treats everyone here well."

"She threatened me. And she threatened you, on the side."

That got the other eye open.

"Threatened me how?"

"That if I don't succeed, or if I cross her, then because you're my friend you might suffer the consequences too." Lark was still holding on to her shoulder. "And I don't want that to happen."

"I don't want that to happen either." Nell pushed herself up onto an elbow and thought about it with the whole of her sleep-addled attention. "I mean. Maybe she's just talking. Let's not find out, though." And then, brightening in a way that was entirely out of proportion to the situation: "But that's so exciting. I never get to do anything exciting."

"Nell."

"No, but it sounds terribly dangerous as well, I know." She was properly awake now. "Look, it sounds like the sort of thing Madame Rooke knows a great deal about. Maybe she can help you. But you have to get on her good side." A yawn got in the way. "Honestly, I think she likes you. She wouldn't hand out a job like that to somebody she didn't."

"Maybe she's picking on me and I haven't noticed."

“Picking on you in a good way. Testing you.” Nell lay back down. “Trying you out.”

* * *

Felix woke in a tavern he had paid two pennies for, with no job to go to and nowhere he was expected. He went to the Plumb and Bob, because it was the only address he had for any of them.

Aeska saw him from an upstairs window: the top of a head, a satchel with everything a man owns in it, and a ledger under one arm. He went down and let him in and locked the door again behind him, and took him straight up to the room.

“So what happened? You all left and then none of you came back.” Aeska was going up the stairs backwards. “Where are the rest?”

“They went to their own places to sleep. I took a tavern, it wasn’t safe to go across the city.” Felix was already getting the book out. “We were in a fight.”

“A fight. With whom?”

“We don’t know. One man, and two howls.”

Aeska stopped on the landing at that.

He knows what a howl is. Half the guilds in Parvo keep them, and a howl walking at a man’s heel is no more remarkable than a dog at a farmer’s. Two of them down a tunnel under the city, in the dark, with a man on a barricade, is not the same animal at all.

“So somebody really wanted you quiet,” Aeska said.

“Harriet gave me this.” Felix put the ledger into his hands. “She took it out of Theo’s house before any of us got there.”

“Then she is the one who ransacked it.” Aeska turned that over. “She had a key.”

“She had a key.”

He opened the book and went through it page by page, and what he found took the pleasure out of the morning.

Every page had been ruined on purpose. Somebody had gone down the entries with ink and blotted each one out, left column and right column both, working carefully enough that nothing showed through and nothing could be lifted off again. Four or five pages of it. Two columns, a great many lines, every one of them put beyond reading by a patient hand.

The last two entries on the most recent page had been left alone.

On the left of each, in Parvosi, a place. On the right, in Technic, which Aeska reads and writes, a serial number and a quantity.

Fexfield Scrappers	7731-QD-0450	50
Claringbold's Yard	7731-QD-0451	30

Aeska read the second line twice, and then the first one again, and then put the book down on the bed.

"I do not know these numbers."

Felix looked up at the way he said it. Aeska was raised inside the Guild of Engineers and taught to run it, and he can read a serial number off a plate the way most men read a shop sign. There is very little that guild handles which he could not name from the label alone.

"I recognise what they are. They are machine numbers. I do not recognise what machines." He sat back. "I should."

"The rest is gone."

"The rest is gone." He tapped the second line. "But that one is Claringbold's Yard, and our friend Billy works at Claringbold's Yard."

"We could go there."

"Not alone, I think." Aeska was already reaching for paper. "You have no way of reaching any of the others?"

"None."

So he copied the two lines out by hand, both names and all the numbers. The ledger itself he left hidden in the room, rather than carry a thing somebody had already killed for out through the streets.

Then the two of them went down and opened the front door.

Lark was standing on the other side of it with her hand up to knock.

"Oh." She took a step back. "Well. I thought this was the right place to find you."

"Long story short." Aeska got the door shut behind him. "We are going to Claringbold's Yard. Come with us and I will explain on the way."

She went with them, and did not mention the bathhouse, or Madame Rooke, or the job she had been given at seven that morning.

* * *

The gate of Claringbold's Yard was shut when they got there, and the three of them stood in front of it, and none of them had ever been to a scrapyard on business in their lives.

Aeska knocked.

Inside, Billiam heard somebody knocking on the iron and did not go anywhere near it. The yard is walled with patchwork and gantry and the arms of old cranes. There is a place at the corner of the office building that he has climbed before, on days when the knocking might have been enforcers, and he went up it now and put his head over the top like a boy looking out of a fort.

Felix. Aeska. Lark.

"Hey." He leaned over the edge. "What are you lot doing here?"

"Hello, Billy." Lark had her hands up to shade her eyes. "We were looking for you."

He came down and unlatched the gate and let them in, and then latched it again behind them, which in two years of working there he had never once bothered to do.

"What are you here for? What's going on?"

Aeska told him, standing just inside the gate. That while the two of them were at Billiam's house the other three had gone down into the Bellows and got into a fight with a man and two howls, and very nearly not come out of it. That the man had escaped. That Felix had come back with something that had been taken out of Theo's house on the night he died.

"And one of the places written in it is here." He took out the copied page. "Which is why this is where I have come."

Billiam looked at the numbers.

Billiam can recognise Technic on sight, because it is the language on the plate of every machine that comes through that gate. He cannot read a word of it. So Aeska read the two strings out to him instead, one and then the other.

The second one stopped him where he stood.

He had heard that number before. Shrapnel had put a hand on a machine in this yard a few weeks back and made him look at the plate and read it off to him, and had said something about it at the time that Billiam had not thought about since.

"That one," he said. "I know that number."

Then he looked round at the three of them standing inside his gate.

"But listen. This is a really bad time to be investigating anything here."

* * *

Then he took them through the yard and showed them the rest of it, and all three

of them went quiet as they walked.

"There's nobody here. The place is trashed. Shrapnel, that's my boss, he isn't here either, and none of the others are." He was walking ahead of them. "And the bullyboys have been damaged. I've been trying to fix them all morning."

"Nobody at all, on a working day?" Aeska said.

"Are there supposed to be a lot of people here?" said Lark.

"Five or six others, usually," Billiam said. "Plus me."

Then they came round the stacks and found the two constructs, and nobody said anything for a moment.

Steam Bun was still on his side where Billiam had left him, still steaming. Shepherd was up, and the moment it registered Billiam among the four of them it came across the ground on its three legs and put its lamp against his chest and left it there.

Billiam put a hand up onto the shoulder without appearing to notice that he had.

"They seem very attached to you," Aeska said.

"Well. Yeah. We've been hanging about together a while." He rubbed the plating with his thumb. "This one's Shepherd. That's Steam Bun on the ground."

"I have tinker's tools, and I fix things for a living," Aeska was already going down on his heels beside the missing leg. "Let me look at him."

While Aeska looked, the rest of them got at the numbers properly.

What Billiam remembered, once he had the serial in front of him, was the whole of it. A machine had come into the yard a few weeks ago that none of them had seen the like of before. Newer than anything they handled, better made, a generation ahead of the ordinary run of scrap, and they had broken it down the way they break everything down and pulled the essence cores out of it.

There had been fifteen cores in it.

Shrapnel had looked at them for a long time. He had said they were odd. Different from a normal core, he said, and stronger than they had any business being. Then he had put them in a box and taken the box away, and Billiam had never seen those cores again.

That by itself was strange. A box of cores is the most valuable object in a scrapyard, the entire reason the trade exists, and normally it sits under a lock where everybody can see it sitting until it is sold.

And that machine had not been the only one. A second of the same make had come in afterwards.

"Fifteen," Billiam said slowly. "And then fifteen again."

"Thirty." Aeska did not look up from the leg he was failing to attach. "Which is the number written next to this yard in a dead man's book."

“So they were looking for the cores.” Billiam had gone somewhere else. “Thirty cores that they thought were still here.”

“It would explain a great deal.” Aeska sat back on his heels. “The howls we are all suddenly meeting are not the howls I grew up around. They are faster and they do not stop. And the man on that barricade was carrying a weapon he had to do something to before he fired it, which is not a thing an ordinary man carries about the city.” He looked at Billiam. “Your Shrapnel took those cores away himself. Is there anywhere he might have put them that whoever tore this place apart would not have found?”

“I don’t know. I thought he’d just sell them.” Billiam turned round and looked at the office. “The only place I can think of is the back room. And that’s empty too.”

“Then either he sold them,” Aeska said, “or he put them somewhere nobody here knows about.”

“Or they took him somewhere.” Billiam said it to the ground. “Some kind of holding place. A jail.”

“There is no jail.” Aeska said it gently enough. “Not the way you mean. If a guild takes a man, it keeps him in its own tower. That is where people go.”

“There’s no way Shrapnel left this place on his own,” Billiam said.

“No.” Aeska got up and wiped his hands. “It rather looks as though he was made to.”

* * *

Billiam went and found a replacement leg out of the stacks, and they set about fitting it, and with their hands busy it got easier to say things.

“Aeska.” Billiam was holding the joint steady. “Why did you leave?”

“Because I did not think my being there would help anything between you and your father.” He was working the fitting round. “It was already difficult in that room before he ever came through the door, and I would not have improved it.” He glanced up. “I apologise for going without saying anything. At the time it seemed the better thing to do.”

“How do you know him?” Billiam said.

Aeska did not answer immediately.

“Your father worked closely with my father. Before. On projects I was never told anything about.” He turned the leg. “They disclosed nothing to me.”

“What’s your father’s name?” Billiam said.

“You know my name. So you will already know it, unless your father has never told you.”

Billiam stopped what he was doing.

“Does it start with a V?”

“Yes.” Aeska did not look up. “My father’s name is Valerin.”

Valerin Volan.

Billiam had gone through his father’s things more than once over the last year. Not to steal anything and not to catch him out, but because a man who is never home is a question, and Billiam had wanted the answer badly enough to open drawers for it. There are papers in that house marked VV. He had found them and turned them over and put them back, and had never had the first idea what the two letters stood for. He had been handed the second letter on his own back step the night before, and it had not once occurred to him to set it beside the first until this moment.

They were recent. That was the part. Not two years old, not from whenever it was that Aeska Volan stopped existing as far as his family were concerned. Recent.

“They must still be working together,” he said.

“We can assume that they may be.” Aeska set the leg down and left it. “I have no contact and no way of knowing. I have not been back in two years.”

“And your father worked with mine. And now my father tells me to stay away from you and to turn myself in to the Guild of Engineers.” Billiam heard how that sounded as he said it. “I’m not going to do it, by the way. I told him I would. That’s why I was afraid you’d overheard us out there.”

“I heard nothing. I left almost the moment the two of you went out to the yard.” A pause. “What did he tell you? About me, about the work, about any of it?”

Billiam told him. All of it, or nearly: the prison, the years, the advice to hand over where Aeska slept in exchange for leniency, and the line about being removed from the board one way or another.

“There is a reason he does not want you anywhere near this,” Aeska said at the end of it. “A man does not tell his own son to go to prison to keep him out of something small.”

Then Billiam stopped with the wrench still in his hand.

“Calder’s his apprentice.”

“What?”

“My father’s new research student is Calder.” He was working it as he said it. “If anybody knows what my father’s been doing, it’s him.”

“Then we ask him.”

“Do you think he’s against us?”

That was Lark, who had come back round the stacks and had been standing there longer than either of them had noticed.

“Or against you, Mr Aeska.” She had come a few steps closer without seeming to. “He’s the one who works with the professor. Information about us could come out of him without him even meaning it. And there was a man in that chamber last night who knew exactly where we were going to be.”

“Wait.” Billiam had got up. “Do you think he’s a double agent?”

“All right. Calm down, both of you.” Aeska put a hand up. “For now you are making sense, which is the problem. We have to hold it as a possibility.” He looked from one of them to the other. “And I do not think Felix has told you the specifics of the fight. That Calder went after the man rather than helping the other two.”

“He hasn’t,” Lark said.

“Then consider that as well, and consider also that he has been with us through all of this from the first night.” He got to his feet. “I am afraid there is nothing to be done about it except ask him, to his face, and watch him while he answers.”

“He said he was going back to the College,” Lark said.

“Then he will be at the College.” Billiam got up off the ground. “They hardly ever leave the place. They’re quite boring, generally.”

* * *

Aeska tried the leg again and it came off again. Then he sat back and put a hand out, and a hand that was not there closed round the joint and held it steady for him.¹ It made no difference whatsoever. Constructs are not machines, whatever they look like, and Aeska has spent his life around machines.

In the middle of it Billiam turned round and looked at Lark properly for the first time all morning.

“Lark. Can I ask you something?”

“Yes?”

“Why do you smell like you tried to have a bath and it didn’t work?”

Lark went crimson.

“Because I did have a bath.” She was already defending herself. “And then I

¹**Mage Hand.** A hand conjured out of nothing, which will lift, fetch, hold and turn a thing at a distance, and has no strength in it worth the name. Most people who can make one use it to open doors they are not standing next to.

had to clean every bath in the building, which took until two in the morning, so.”

“How many baths have you got?”

“It’s a bathhouse. It’s not my bathhouse.” She got a hand up. “And actually that brings me to something I have to ask you, Mr Aeska.”

She told him where she had slept, and why, and what cleaning the place all night had bought her.

“And this morning the woman who owns it offered me a job,” she said. “A proper one. A place to stay. She wants one thing for it.”

“Which is?”

“You.”

Aeska did not move at all.

“She wants me to find out whether Aeska Volan is at the Plumb and Bob. Whether you play there. Whether the people who drink in it know your face.” Lark was watching him while she said it. “And then she sells that to whoever is paying her, and I don’t know who that is.”

“And you have been standing next to me since this morning.”

“Yes.”

She let that sit, and then said the part that had actually frightened her.

“She used your surname, Mr Aeska. Not a musician. Not a man with a lute who plays the Stacks. Aeska Volan.”

Aeska stood in a wrecked scrapyard and took that without any visible change at all.

“Not for good reasons, I would think.” He said it quite evenly. “My first meeting with somebody wearing the mark of my own guild was not a friendly one. I can only assume that whoever is asking wants me removed.”

“Then what if you did the opposite?” Lark said.

“The opposite.”

“Make yourself known.” She was working it out as she spoke and it came out in a rush. “You’re hiding, and they’re looking, and they only have to be lucky once. But if everybody knew who you were. What if you became the next Theodore Blackwood? If you stood where he stood, then hurting you costs them something.”

“I don’t think Theodore was very safe, Lark,” Billiam said.

“Well, of course not.” She had gone pink again. “But the Guild of Engineers is enormous. If they want a man gone and nobody would notice him going, they can take all the time they like. The only thing that ever makes that hard is other people watching.”

Aeska did not answer at once.

“If the Guild of Engineers want me dead, it makes very little difference whether I am public or hidden.” He said it without heat. “What going public does

is bring more people into it. People who have no business being in it at all.” He picked the leg up again and looked at it. “For now I would rather keep moving, and use what we have.

“All of this because I would not do what I was told.” He turned the leg over in his hands. “They wanted me to be the next Doctor Tammerton. It is not what I want. And I could not say so, because to say so is to be a disgrace to my family.” A short breath that was not quite a laugh. “And now I am a disgrace to my family regardless, and I am running.”

* * *

Felix had gone quiet a while back, and nobody had thought anything of it.

He had been working the whole time. For ten minutes he had been sitting on an upturned crate with his eyes almost shut and his hands loose on his knees, putting something together in his head a piece at a time. Some spells are thrown. This one has to be built first.

Then he opened his eyes and stood up and went over to Shepherd, and all three of them turned to watch him do it.

“Because I have talked to machines before,” he said. “Maybe I can talk to this one.”

“You have what?”

“I have talked to a Scratcher before.” He said it as though this were ordinary. “It talked back.”

Aeska put a hand on his shoulder as he passed, and a low radiant warmth went into it and stayed there, and Felix crouched down in front of the three-legged construct.

The thing turned its lamp on him and waited. It did not know it could understand him until he spoke.²

“Have you seen anything happen here this morning?” Felix said.

“Yes.”

Lark took a step back without meaning to.

“What happened?” said Felix.

“Big bad time.” The voice came out of the lamp housing flat and unhurried. “Bang. Bang. Bang. Bang.”

²**Speak with Machines.** A slow spell, laid on rather than thrown, which opens a channel to a made thing for a while. It does not grant intelligence, and a bullyboy is not clever. It can tell you what happened in front of it, in as many words as it has.

“What did the other people look like?”

“Other people big,” said the construct. “Green coat. Blonde man. Very fast.”

Felix said it again over his shoulder for the rest of them, because he was the only one who could hear what the thing was actually saying.

Billiam went very still.

“That’s him,” he said. “The one from the square. The one that got hold of Lark.”

“The one you spat on, Billy,” said Lark.

“Ask it about Shrapnel,” Aeska said. “Ask whether it saw what happened to him.”

“Was Shrapnel taken away with them?” Felix said.

“Boss taken. Yes.”

“Did they carry anything out of the office?”

“No.” A pause of a sort. “Smash. Smash.”

And that was as much as a bullyboy had.

* * *

So it was the Porter’s Guild, which was not what Billiam had assumed at all.

He had been carrying an idea for two days that the people who came round leaning on Shrapnel and the people in the green coats were the same, and standing in his own wrecked yard he found out that they were not. The men who turn up at Claringbold’s for the rent are the Corewright’s Association, who own the yard and own a great many yards like it, and who are a normal and irritating fact of his working life. The people who took his boss are the other ones. The ones in green, who choke people in public squares.

“Two different guilds,” he said. “They were just arseholes doing their job.”

“Yes.”

“And this lot are something else.” He looked round the yard. “Everything is so completely fucked.”

They did not stay much longer. There was nothing to stay for, and nobody came, and in the end Billiam latched a gate on an empty yard he no longer had a job at and walked away from it with the other three.

On the way, they worked out that the Plumb and Bob could not go on being where they met. Two nights running, trouble had come through its door looking for them, and Harl had said his piece, and Aeska said the rest of it plainly.

“I am running out of credit with that man very quickly. We cannot keep spending it.”

“Somewhere nearer the Bellows,” Lark said. “The guild sorts don’t go down that way. Not the upper ones.”

* * *

Calder spent the whole of that day in the College, and did not leave it until the middle of the afternoon.

He had been turning something over since the Bellows, and by the morning he had it.

He had come within a few feet of a construct built to kill him, and he had thrown everything he had at it and hit nothing at all. Two of the four people in that chamber had gone down. One of them had very nearly not got up again, and Calder had been the one kneeling over him with both hands pressed into the hole in his leg.

For as long as he has been at the College, not being good enough has meant a poor mark, or a supervisor’s raised eyebrow, or a place lost to somebody cleverer. It has never meant anything else. It means something else now. It means Felix on his back on wet stone, and Lark under a construct, and Calder standing eight feet away with nothing in his hands that works.

So he worked.

He was in the library before the morning bell. He went through the shelves he is allowed and sent for one of the ones he is not, and he filled pages. New spells copied out in Arcan in his own hand, with the margins ruled the way he was taught, and notes down the side of each of them, and the workings set out underneath.

He carried the notebook back to his room after midday and sat over it there until he could raise any of them without looking at the page.

It was the hardest he had worked at anything in a year, and nobody made him do it, and there was nobody in the room to see him do it.

Then somebody knocked, and one of the College staff handed him a letter at his own door.

“Master Calder. This came for you.”

It was from Professor Buckman.

Most of it was the work. Calder had sent him three pages on whether the elemental modes can be treated as axes at all, and the reply went through it properly, question by question, in the way a supervisor does when he has read the thing and taken it seriously. Calder got most of the way down it with the ordinary small

pleasure of being answered.

Then, at the bottom, the postscript. He had asked, at the end of his own letter, and only at the end, whether the Professor happened to know anything about a weapon that could do what the weapon in Oblong Square had done.

Calder, I recommend that you stop this line of inquiry. It is not relevant to your College duties, and the practical application of magic for aggressive purposes, weapons and the like, is not something we particularly care to delve into at the College. I would prefer that you did not pursue it.

He read it twice and put it in his pack, and it did not strike him as strange at all. It sounded exactly like the man he had worked under for three years, and the College really does not delve into that sort of thing, and a supervisor telling a research student to stay on his own subject is the most ordinary sentence in the world.

He went out about three and walked across the city to the Plumb and Bob, and came in at the front of it like an ordinary customer.

* * *

The tavern was almost empty when he got there, as it often is on a working afternoon. Harl caught his eye from behind the bar and tipped his head at the back room, and then winked one eye, and then the other one.

He knocked on the door of the back room and opened it, and found four people sitting round a table with nothing on it, looking at him.

“Hello,” he said.

Nobody said hello back.

“It’s good you’re here.” Billiam got there first. “We’ve got some things we need to talk about.”

“What is going on?” Calder had stopped just inside the door. “I come in and everybody is silent and we need to talk. Am I in trouble?”

“Felix has told me what happened to the three of you.” Aeska had not moved. “And Lark has filled in some of the rest. We would like to hear it from you. Sit down and tell us.”

And then Lark got up and crossed the room at him.

She took both of his hands in hers and got up onto her toes to put her face as close to his as her height would allow, which was not very close, and looked directly into his eyes from about a foot below them.

“Calder. Can we trust you? For real?”

Calder looked down at her with an expression of total bewilderment.

"Of course you can trust me." She still had hold of his arms and showed no sign of letting go. "Lark, what has happened? You are all being extremely odd."

Lark let go of him. Aeska turned a chair round and sat down on it and waited, and so did everybody else.

So Calder told them, in order, start to finish. That the three of them had gone down to meet Harriet, that he and Lark had hung back at the tunnel mouth while Felix went out, that there had been a shot out of the dark and then an ambush. That there had been howls, modified ones, nothing like the ordinary sort, and that they had barely got out of that chamber at all.

"Calder." Aeska put both forearms on the table. "There is one thing on my mind, and I would rather say it than sit here thinking it. Lark tells me that when the shooting started you went after the man with the gun, instead of staying with Felix, who was at that point being attacked by two of those things." He kept his voice entirely level. "I am not saying you abandoned anybody. I am asking what your reasoning was. Because from the outside it looks as though catching the culprit interested you more than helping your own."

Calder took a moment with that one.

"I do not know how it was described to you." He looked at Lark and at Felix and then back. "But at the moment I went, they were doing fine. Felix is a big man and he was standing and Lark was between him and the thing. And the only person in that room who knew anything at all was getting away."

He put a hand flat on the table.

"We have pieces. We have a great many pieces and not one of them fits another. We are missing whatever sits in the middle, and we are missing anybody with any actual knowledge of what is going on. And he was the one person in the whole of it who could have put it together for us." A breath. "I thought that if we took him, we could learn something. I did not know how. It was not my intention that Felix or Lark should go down while I was doing it."

"I can see the reasoning," Aeska said. "However. We nearly lost the only piece of information we have, because you were chasing another one."

"And there is something else." He volunteered it before anybody asked for it. "I was not certain he was running. He was up on that balcony and everything happened quickly, but I had hit him, and Felix hit him as well."

"Poison," Felix said.

"And then he went down behind the stone, and we could not see him. I did not know whether he was leaving or taking cover and about to start shooting again." He turned a hand over. "So it was two things at once. Get to him before he could fire again. And take him, if he was still there."

Aeska watched all of that from four feet away, with his eyes on Calder's hands as much as on his face.

Calder was telling the truth. The whole of it, without leaving anything in the corners.

"Well." Aeska sat back. "Then pardon me for the questioning."

* * *

"And it's a spooky coincidence," Lark said, "that you work for the professor who is also Billy's dad, who also somehow knows Mr Aeska."

Calder's head came round.

"Did you say Benjamin is Billy's father?"

Everybody looked at Billiam.

"Yeah." He had gone red to the ears. "He is my father. So when I said I was his apprentice, I wasn't being completely honest with you. I didn't lie, exactly. I was his apprentice. But yeah. He's my father."

Calder sat down for the first time since coming in.

"And that's why it's good you're here." Billiam had started talking faster. "Because me and Aeska worked out today that my father and his father used to work together on something, and maybe still do, and it's all very secret. And I was hoping that since you've been working under him, you might know more about what he's actually doing."

"I am beginning to see how this looks from where you are sitting." Calder said it slowly. "But I know nothing at all about his projects. He went off-site indefinitely and left word that I was to carry on by myself. And I wrote to him." He got the letter out of his pack. "And this morning he wrote back."

He put it on the table and let them read the last paragraph of it.

"I asked him whether he knew anything about the weapon that killed Theo," he said. "And he told me not to look into it. Because magic is supposed to be for good purposes."

"This is a good purpose," Lark said.

"Yes," Calder said. "But developing magic for weapons is not what the College does."

"He's hiding something," Billiam said. "And he wants me out of it."

"He wants you to give yourself in," said Lark.

Calder looked up from the letter.

"He wants you to what?"

So they told him about the back step and the window boxes. And about a father who had worked out, in the space of one evening, that the cleanest way through this for his son was two years in a guild cell, and had said so out loud.

“What the hell happened yesterday?” Calder said.

“A great deal,” Aeska said.

“Well.” Calder folded the letter back up. “Now that I have all of it, I agree that it looks strange from outside. But I am not in any part of his project, and I had nothing to do with the killing, and I did not try to get either of these two killed in a tunnel.”

“You did save Felix,” Lark said. “Thank you for that.”

“I stopped the bleeding.”

“Luckily,” Felix said.

“Just in time,” said Calder, and left it there.

* * *

After that it was planning, which took the rest of the afternoon and did not feel like progress.

Calder read the ledger himself, or as much of it as anybody can read. He can recognise Technic on a page and not a word more, so Aeska had to tell him what the two surviving lines said, and he sat looking at the blotted pages above them for a long time.

Billiam knew the other name. Fexfield Scrappers is over in the Core, a proper industrial operation with twenty or thirty on the books, nothing like the salvage yard he works at, and a place with that many hands could get through a great deal more of anything than Claringbold’s ever could. Which fits a fifty against a thirty.

So there were two ends to pull on: a scrapyard in the Core, and a guild tower with a man in it.

They split it up. Billiam would go to Claringbold’s first thing to see whether anybody had come back, and then across to Fexfield and meet Felix there at ten. Aeska, Lark and Calder would find out what they could about the Porter’s Guild, and whether five people could get into its tower. That is where Shrapnel almost certainly is. There are no civic prisons in Parvo, and a guild keeps what it takes.

They still had nowhere to meet. They left that unsolved. The only answers were a tavern they could not afford and a tavern they were no longer welcome in.



In the evening Calder put on the plain cloak from the box in his old room, and the respirator, and the smoked goggles. Then he went down into the parts of the city where he does his other work, and started asking about the Porter's Guild.

He got almost nothing.

Most of the people he asked genuinely did not know anything. There is no reason an ordinary person should know how a guild is run. What he did get, from two or three of the sort who usually talk to him for a penny, was something he had not expected: not ignorance but a shutter coming down. A change of subject. A look that said this is not a thing I discuss, said by men who discuss almost anything.

He came back up out of it with one fact, and it was not the fact he had gone looking for. Whatever the Porter's Guild is, people in the Stacks would rather not be heard having an opinion about it.

Aeska played that night, because a bard who suddenly stops playing the tavern he always plays is a bard who has told everybody something. It was the middle of the week and the room was thin, and he took a ducat and a mark out of it, which is as much as that night is worth. He played well. He was thinking, the whole way through, about his own face, and how much of it a person could change, and how quickly.

And Lark walked back across the Stacks to Salador's.

She had been asked for one thing and she had it. She had spent the day beside the man himself, and she could say with perfect truth that Aeska Volan is known at the Plumb and Bob, performs there, and sleeps in a room over its bar. It was the easiest task anybody had been set all day, and she had solved it before it was given to her.

She went in the front. She went up the wooden stairs past the five doors and the sixth, and up the next flight, and stopped outside the heavy one at the top.

Then she stood there with her hand up, and did not knock yet.